

McKinsey Clee Scholarship Application 2025 - Naomi Ivie

Growing up in Nigeria, I saw firsthand what a lack of access to education could do to a child's future. On the way to school, I'd see children my age hawking on the streets; making a choice between attending school or eating. At the same time, I observed how systemic inefficiencies drained Nigeria's potential. Millions wasted in human capital and natural resources in a country of great promise did not seem coincidental. I knew Nigeria couldn't reach her full potential without tackling her educational problem first, and I was determined to pave the way with the toolkit I was beginning to develop.

That conviction led me to the African Leadership Academy, a school founded by Acha Leke, Senior Partner at McKinsey, and Fred Swaniker, McKinsey alum. There, I led the academy's tenth annual leadership and diplomacy conference, ALAMAU, convening two hundred delegates from over thirty countries. Over three days, the students analyzed political, social, and economic systems in real African governments and presented actionable policy proposals. The conference strengthened youth leadership networks across the continent and sparked twelve youth-led initiatives across five regions. These initiatives ranged from addressing education reform to economic inclusion, and gender equity. This experience showed me how collaborative problem-solving could drive change beyond borders.

After the conference, I sought to expand my impact. At Yale Young Global Scholars, I co-founded Education for Equality, a nonprofit aimed at increasing access to learning resources during COVID-19. We launched decentralized learning hubs to broadcast content to students in non-Wi-Fi-enabled regions. Within three months, our pilot reached over fifty students in two Lagos communities, improving learning outcomes and post-pandemic school attendance. Upon graduation, I joined the YYGS Global Ambassador team, where I later mentored high-potential

McKinsey Clee Scholarship Application 2025 - Naomi Ivie

youth in launching their own social initiatives. Witnessing the ripple effect driven by thoughtful design, strategic implementation, and cross-cultural collaboration affirmed my desire to work at the intersection of education, strategy, and global development, which is what leads me to McKinsey today.

For me, management consulting is not just a career path, it's a way to scale impact. I'm drawn to its rigor, its emphasis on asking the right questions, and its proximity to decision-makers who can invoke systemic change. McKinsey, in particular, embodies what I value most: analytical excellence, bold leadership, and a deep commitment to solving the world's most urgent problems. Its work with multinational nonprofits and governments represents the level of strategic thinking required to drive educational reform at scale.

Working at McKinsey will provide the perfect opportunity for me to continue creating a global impact in education. At McKinsey, I'm excited to contribute my firsthand knowledge of youth development in Africa, while learning from the firm's global network of leaders and problem-solvers. I will be able to sit across from decision-makers and ask, "how do we build something that lasts?" just as I once did at ALAMAU and YYGS. The Clee Scholarship will enable me to continue creating global impact and transform the future of Nigeria - and Africa, through education.